MOAB: Mother of All *Bluffs*

The Trump administration has been pulling a lot of triggers recently, but the guns have been empty. Iran sticks the nozzle in its mouth and mocks the intentions of a nation that has lost all credibility. Iran doesn't even think the eagle is bluffing anymore. It thinks it is delusional, as Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi has pointed out. The US needs to be reminded that threats, especially empty ones, are not simply failures of signalling. They signal the wrong intentions. As many a political philosopher has established, signalling needs to be costly, or bluffs will be called. Nuclear arsenals built. Chemical weapons used. And Crimeas invaded.

The latest addition to Trump's arsenal of (empty) threats is the GBU-43/B Massive Ordnance Air Blast bomb, popularly nicknamed the "Mother of All Bombs" by the US military. Reports suggest that the Trump administration is considering using the MOAB against Iran's Pickaxe Mountain, where an underground nuclear facility is suspected to be located. But whether there is any credibility to that threat remains to be seen. Could this Mother of All Bombs simply be the Mother of All Bluffs?

Trump's exaggerated threats, inconsistency, and the general fuzziness surrounding his "Will he/Won't he" attitude have been attributed to a cold, calculated tactic, otherwise known as the "Madman Theory." But this theory only works when at least some of his more extreme threats are followed through on. In an independent analysis of 22 documented threats and warnings issued by Trump between February 28 and October 16, 2026, this author found that only four were followed by broader military action, while eight were postponed or called off. Even these four instances do not necessarily establish that the specific threatened action was carried out. The remaining ten were either not fulfilled as threatened or could not be verified. (See Appendix)

The problem is not simply that the threats go unfulfilled. It is that an all-too familiar Iran may have learned to anticipate what comes next.

This latest MOAB threat, then, follows a series of threats that were, well, not followed through on. On multiple occasions, the United States has promised to unleash the four horsemen of the apocalypse on Iran, but then something would change that. After promising to destroy Iran's energy infrastructure, they had a productive conversation. Or the US would obliterate an entire civilization, but oh, it's just the day after Easter, and everyone likes bunnies, right? And they were eager enough to come to the negotiating table. And we like their smiles.

But for some threats, the lack of follow-through is rather predictable. Attacks on civilian infrastructure cannot simply be used to coerce the hand of the state. Under international humanitarian law, civilian infrastructure is protected from direct attack unless it qualifies as a military objective, and even then, the anticipated military advantage must not be outweighed by excessive incidental harm to civilians. Threatening to violate the Geneva Conventions is easier than actually doing so. Carrying out such threats comes with legal and diplomatic repercussions that make them rather costly for the US to see through. This, of course, does not mean that the Geneva Conventions cannot be violated, or that violations have

not occurred in the course of this war. It does, however, make sweeping threats to obliterate civilian infrastructure less believable.

But even if we were to ignore the reputation for deception that has been created, is there any value to this particular threat? The technical specifications suggest otherwise.

Reports suggest that the MOAB is being considered for use against Pickaxe Mountain, where Iran is suspected of housing nuclear facilities. But issues persist. The facility is estimated to lie more than 250 feet underground, while the MOAB is designed to detonate at or near the surface. It is not a bunker-buster. More than that, the MOAB must be delivered by an MC-130 transport aircraft, which lacks the stealth capabilities of the B-2 bomber, making it more vulnerable to Iranian air defences. Even if all these obstacles vanished, there remains the question of what exactly the United States would be destroying. Satellite assessments have raised doubts about whether the underground facility is even operational. If the MOAB cannot achieve its goals, and worse still, has no goals to achieve, how believable is the idea that the US will spend money on what will be empty grandstanding.

Then there is the issue of the electoral calendar in the US. The threat to use the MOAB against Iran comes a week after Trump announced that they will not be attacking Iran at any time prior to the Midterm Elections to be held in the United States on November 3rd. It is never a good idea to announce such intentions when deterrence depends on uncertainty anyway, but it also goes to show that an attack is not imminent. Besides, the threat is rather vague, with no stated red lines - or deadlines. It invites disbelief, but also comes without a clear demand for action.

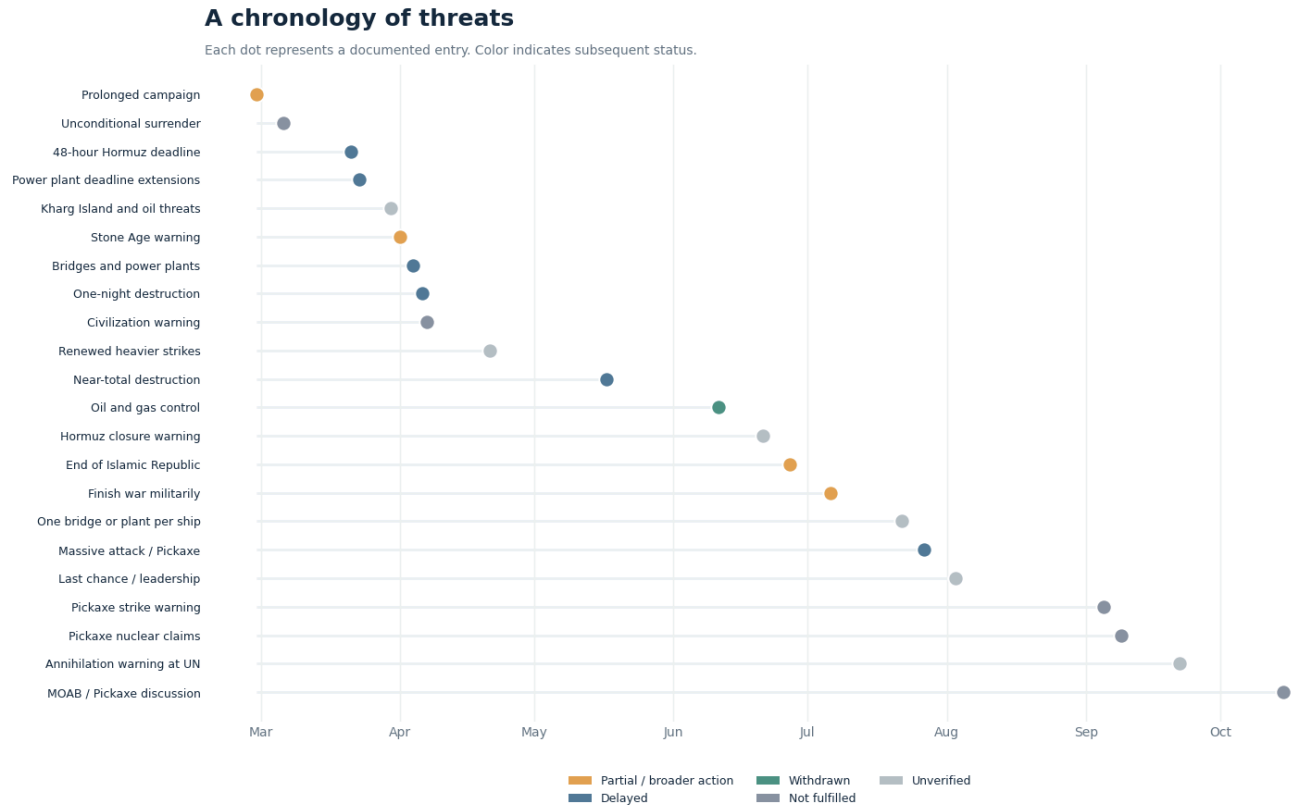
Funnily enough, the US and Israel do not seem aligned on their timelines in Iran either. Israel wants to lay low until its national elections on October 27. Netanyahu worries about Iranian strikes on Israel before the elections, and that the opposition might try to construe those attacks as having been provoked by Netanyahu to disrupt the elections. *"Even if Iran fires missiles at us they will blame me,"* worries Netanyahu. This, of course, leaves open the possibility that an attack might happen after November 3.

However, the further military action is pushed into the future, the more time Washington has to repeat a now-familiar pattern: issue an extraordinary threat, enter another round of negotiations, and then present Iran's willingness to talk as sufficient reason to hold off on an attack. If Tehran has learned to anticipate this sequence, the threat of escalation may become less a reason to concede than an invitation to buy time. A threat too far in the future, or one that can always be postponed, is difficult to believe.

Handing out empty threats to an IRGC-managed Iran is not very smart. As Dr. Mehrzad Boroujerdi points out, these are battle-hardened officials, many of whom have experience in conflicts across Bosnia, Syria, Lebanon, and, most importantly, the Iran-Iraq War. They came from nothing and are something now because of war. If given the choice between cowering and provoking the USA to lay its cards on the table, they are unlikely to cower. And it does not seem that the US will play its ace, or even any of its face cards.

It is a multiplayer world, and Trump would be smart to remember that other adversaries are watching too.

Appendix:


A chronology of threats
Each dot represents a documented entry. Color indicates subsequent status.
Prolonged campaign
Unconditional surrender
48-hour Hormuz deadline
Power plant deadline extensions
Kharg Island and oil threats
Stone Age warning
Bridges and power plants
One-night destruction
Civilization warning
Renewed heavier strikes
Near-total destruction
Oil and gas control
Hormuz closure warning
End of Islamic Republic
Finish war militarily
One bridge or plant per ship
Massive attack / Pickaxe
Last chance / leadership
Pickaxe strike warning
Pickaxe nuclear claims
Annihilation warning at UN
MOAB / Pickaxe discussion
Mar
Apr
May
Jun
Jul
Aug
Sep
Oct
Partial / broader action
Delayed
Withdrawn
Not fulfilled
Unverified